Making municipal decisions easier to understand

How might we help residents understand a proposed municipal decision, how it could affect them, and when they can have a say?

Build a working proof of concept that a municipality could realistically pilot. It can be a web app, data tool, map, dashboard or another format. A municipal leader should be able to use it without your team in the room.

The problem

Municipal decisions on zoning, budgets, bylaws, transit and infrastructure shape daily life more directly than any other level of government. Municipal councils make decisions every week that impact residents: zoning changes, budgets, bike lanes, development applications, fees and service levels. However, council decisions are spread across agendas, minutes and staff reports that most residents never read. A single item can run to hundreds of pages written in planning and legal language. Residents need a clear way to find an issue, understand what it means, and know whether they can still influence it.

Public engagement happens at set points: statutory notices, public meetings, delegation deadlines and comment periods. However, comment windows are often short and easy to miss. Most residents only learn about a decision once it's made, or once construction starts.

Toronto publishes council and committee agendas, reports, recommendations and decisions. Agendas can change as material is added, and a proposal may be amended before a final decision is made. Explaining an issue accurately can require connecting several records. [1]

Residents can submit written comments and speak at certain committee or board meetings, but the process depends on the meeting and item. The tool needs to distinguish an upcoming opportunity for input from a decision that has already been made. [2] There is a need for tools that translate, personalize and time information: telling a resident what is proposed near them, what it would change, and the next date they can act.

How common and persistent it is

- Only 20% of Canadians say they have ever taken part in a municipal public consultation, and just 9% say they are very likely to in the future (Ipsos and Municipal World).
- Ontario's average municipal election turnout fell to a record low of about 36% in 2022, down from 38.3% in 2018. Over 40 years, it has never risen above 40% (AMO).
- In a City of Toronto survey, residents' top challenges were that information is hard to find and that they are unaware of ways to give input.

Questions to investigate

- What makes municipal agendas, staff reports and minutes difficult for residents to understand, and which details are essential to preserve when simplifying them?
- How can residents follow a proposal through multiple meetings and distinguish what is proposed, what has been decided and what remains open?

- When and how can residents provide input, and how can those opportunities be made clear before a deadline passes?
- What information helps residents understand how a proposed decision could affect them and their neighbourhood?
- How can municipalities show how public input was considered, even if it did not change the final decision?
- How could a tool help municipal staff explain decisions clearly while keeping information accurate, current, and linked to its sources?

What it costs

- Delays and rework as late opposition can trigger appeals, deferrals and redesigns that a clear early explanation might have avoided.
- Missing voices with renters, newcomers, students and shift workers being least likely to participate, so decisions reflect a narrow slice of the community.
- Legitimacy is a concern as decisions made without broad understanding are more likely to be contested and less likely to be trusted.
- Today′s tools publish information but rarely explain it. Residents must already know a decision exists, where to find it and how to read it. This favours people with time, expertise, and familiarity with city hall. Participation then reflects a narrow slice of the community, which weakens the quality of decisions.

Who you are designing for

Primary users. Residents looking for understandable information about a municipal issue, including people unfamiliar with council processes. This includes renters, newcomers, youth, seniors and people with lower literacy or limited English. Community groups and residents want to know what was decided and how it affects them. An app alone will also miss people offline.

Municipal users. Clerks, communications staff and engagement teams helping residents find accurate information and could benefit from a tool that makes decisions more transparent and easier to explain. Councillors and their staff who need quick, accurate summaries and a way to communicate them to their constituents.

Other stakeholders. Community associations, local businesses and people affected by a decision. Local journalists and civil advocates who monitor council.

What success looks like

A tool that takes a real municipal decision or staff report and shows, in plain language:

- What is being proposed, and why
- Who and where it affects (″is this near me?″)
- Key dates, and how and when to have a say
- A link back to the source document for every claim , The tool connects its explanation to the original reports and decision, including important amendments or conditions.

- Thought given to who the tool might leave out
- Tested on two or three real agenda items, accurate, and neutral in tone.
- A municipal leader can use the working tool independently and see how it would support public understanding.

Constraints

- Distinguish staff recommendations, committee decisions and final council decisions.
- Show the source and date for each explanation.
- Summaries must preserve important conditions and uncertainty. AI-generated answers need to be checked against the records. A summary that mis-states a decision is worse than no summary. Every summary should link back to the exact source passage.
- Verify participation information on the official item page. Do not infer a submission deadline from a meeting date.
- Use clear, accessible language and avoid displaying unnecessary personal information from public correspondence. Any communications must be non-partisan and presented neutrally.

Technical considerations

- Document parsing as agendas and staff reports are often PDFs with inconsistent structure; extracting the decision, location, timeline and recommendation is non-trivial
- Summarization needs a careful approach because language models can simplify text but can also omit, distort or invent details; summaries should link back to the source and flag uncertainty
- Geolocation when connecting a decision to an address, ward or neighbourhood requires parsing addresses, legal descriptions and maps
- Personalization is important as "how could this affect me" depends on location, tenure, travel patterns and more, which raises data-minimization questions
- Timeline modelling: representing process stages (notice, meeting, decision, appeal) consistently across decision types
- Accessibility including WCAG compliance, plain language, translation and mobile-first design.

Public datasets to explore

You may use other public data that better supports your solution. Record your sources and dates, and make data limitations visible.

1. **Report Request Log City Council and its Committees (City of Toronto data and downloads)**

Contains adopted requests for staff reports, item references, report-back timing and status. Use it to locate council directions and follow reporting links. It covers report requests, not every decision; a closed request does not prove a wider commitment was delivered.

2. **Members of Toronto City Council Voting Record (City of Toronto data and downloads)**

Contains recorded votes, agenda item references, motion descriptions and results. Link these to the official reports and decisions. Read the motion carefully: a vote may concern an amendment, and not every decision has a recorded vote.

Other potential datasets to consider are council and committee agendas, minutes and staff reports from local municipalities; Municipal open data portals (zoning, ward boundaries, development applications); Public notice pages and engagement platforms used by local cities ; Plain-language and accessibility guidelines .

Explain your thinking

Show who the tool serves, why you designed it this way and how you checked its outputs. Include clear instructions, source links and any assumptions. Explain what a municipality would need to test or add before piloting it. If you use AI, make its role and limitations clear.

Background sources

[1] City of Toronto. Be Informed

[2] City of Toronto. Participate in Council and Committee Meetings

[3] City of Toronto. Council agendas reports and decisions